everything real. Saying it set things in motion, automatically. Saying it was a step.

It meant we now had a few more very big steps ahead.

Like…moving in together?

I asked if she'd consider moving to Britain, moving into Nott Cott with me.

We talked about all that would mean, and how it would work, and what she'd be giving up. We talked about the logistics of winding down her life in Toronto. When, and how, and above all…for what? Exactly?

I can't just leave my show and quit my job to give it a shot. Would moving to Britain mean a forever commitment?

Yes, I said. It would.

In that case, she said with a smile, yes.

We kissed, hugged, sat down to our supper.

I sighed. On the road, I thought.

But later, after she'd fallen asleep, I analyzed myself. A holdover from therapy, perhaps. I realized that, mixed in with all my roiling emotions, there was a big streak of relief. She'd said it back, the actual words, *I love you,* and it hadn't been inevitable, it hadn't been a formality. Part of me, I couldn't deny, had been braced for the worst case. *Haz, I'm sorry but I just don't know if I can do this.*…Part of me feared she'd bolt. Go back to Toronto, change her number. Heed the advice of her girlfriends.

Is anyone worth this?

Part of me thought she'd be smart to do so.

31.

BY PURE CHANCE THE 2017 Invictus Games were going to be in Toronto. Meg's backyard. Perfect occasion, the Palace decided, for our first official public outing.

Meg was a bit nervous. Me too. But we had no choice. Has to be done, we said. We've hidden from the world long enough. Also, this would be the most controlled, predictable environment we could ever hope for.